



Popular magic and astrology

Magic merged with philosophy and mystery cults (see pp.44–45) as an interest in esoteric belief systems grew among well-heeled Romans. These beliefs included Pythagoreanism (see p.37); the worship of Isis; and Hermeticism (see pp.134–135), a branch of the philosophical school of Neoplatonism that ascribed the creation of the physical world to a

female power named Hecate. Yet on the teeming streets of Rome, which had about a million inhabitants under the early empire in the 1st century CE, other forms of magic also thrived. For every aristocratic scholar of the occult there were hundreds of soothsayers, *præcantrices* (female sorceresses who sold love potions and performed simple healing rituals), and popular astrologers.

▲ Evil eye mosaic

This mosaic from Antioch shows the evil eye attacked by wild animals and stabbed with weapons. While the eye was defending itself from the assault, it was hoped that it would not turn its gaze on the household.

“Magic rose to such a height that even today it has sway over a great part of mankind.”

PLINY THE ELDER, *NATURAL HISTORY*, c. 77–79 CE